COLORADO SYMPHONY

CLASSIC 2025-2026

Journey with us through a host of magnificent symphonic works that you've come to know and love, reach new heights with elevated guest artists, and explore additional terrains with innovative and diverse programming.

Julia Miyamoto
TEXT Section 104
Boulder CO 80303

**Our State,
Your Symphony.**

November 21-23

The Four Seasons of Buenos Aires with Kerson Leong

Music Director Peter Oundjian leads a rare Denver appearance of the enormously talented violinist Soyoung Yoon, who wows audiences regularly in concert halls across Europe and Asia. She'll steal the show with the music of Argentine tango composer Astor Piazzolla, whose collection of vibrant musical portraits of Buenos Aires pays homage to Vivaldi's own Four Seasons. Next, prepare to be inspired by the music of Brahms, who famously grappled with the challenge of composing a symphony in a post-Beethoven world. After the agonizing two decades it took to complete his first, this Second Symphony sprung forth in just four short months. Inhabiting a shimmering pastoral world with radiant sunshine tempered occasionally by underlying shadows of melancholy, this work is the sweetest and gentlest of Brahms' four treasured symphonies. A weekend of symphonic portraiture opens with Smetana's The Moldau, a musical painting of the Bohemian river of the same name, providing a serene beginning to an evening of symphonic bliss.

Peter Oundjian, conductor
Kerson Leong, violin

SMETANA The Moldau
PIAZZOLLA The Four Seasons of Buenos Aires*
—INTERMISSION—
BRAHMS Symphony No. 2 in D major, Op. 73
*feat. Kerson Leong

January 9-11

Rachmaninoff Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini

Hailed by The New York Times as "thrilling and unabashedly personal," the virtuosity and dynamic stage presence of pianist Makoto Ozone on Rachmaninoff's stunning Paganini Variations would be enough to excite any listener, but seasoned guest conductor Jun Märkl has even more up his sleeve for this weekends' audiences.

From the sizzling sounds of Chabrier's España to the fresh, glistening portrait of springtime in Debussy's Printemps, this concert features a menu of music that will leave no concertgoer hungry – and that's all before your Colorado Symphony performs the music of Stravinsky's iconic ballet Petrushka. This bold work underscores a tantalizing story depicting the love triangle between three puppets and their desires to become flesh and blood. Like its characters, Petrushka's music leaps off the page, eager to participate in the joy of existence as it combines wit, merriment, and reckless abandon with Russian folk elements to cap an evening filled with music that's evocative, beautiful, and just plain fun.

Jun Märkl, conductor
Makoto Ozone, piano

CHABRIER España
RACHMANINOFF Rhapsody on a Theme of Paganini*
—INTERMISSION—
DEBUSSY Printemps
STRAVINSKY Petrushka
*feat. Makoto Ozone

January 23-25

Mozart and Now

Mozart & Now reimagines the concert weekend experience with three unique performances contrasting the music of Mozart alongside contemporary works by some of today's brightest composers. From Friday to Saturday, hear three of Mozart's most revered compositions including the scintillating Symphony No. 35, his "Gran partita" Serenade featuring the entire woodwind section, and the "Coronation" Mass alongside modern works by Joel Thompson, Vivian Fung, and Gabriela Lena Frank.

Sunday's performance is an all-Mozart affair, combining the composer's works from Friday and Saturday into a single showstopping performance. The Colorado Symphony Chorus and a host of vocal soloists will shine on both the "Coronation" Mass and Lena Frank's Conquest Requiem, making this a weekend you won't want to miss.

Peter Oundjian, conductor
Jessica Rivera, soprano
Jennifer Johnson Cano, mezzo soprano
Isaiah Bell, tenor
Andrew Garland, baritone
Colorado Symphony Chorus,
Taylor Martin, director

Friday Repertoire: MOZART Mass in C major, K. 317, "Coronation"; JOEL THOMPSON To Awaken the Sleeper —INTERMISSION— MOZART Serenade No. 10 in B-flat major, K. 361, "Gran partita"
Saturday Repertoire: VIVIAN FUNG Dust Devils
MOZART Symphony No. 35 in D major, K. 385
—INTERMISSION— GABRIELA LENA FRANK Conquest Requiem
Sunday Repertoire: MOZART Symphony No. 35 in D major, K. 385; MOZART Mass in C major, K. 317, "Coronation" —INTERMISSION— MOZART Serenade No. 10 in B-flat major, K. 361, "Gran Partita"

February 6-8

Tchaikovsky Symphony No. 6 "Pathétique"

In declining physical and mental health, Tchaikovsky struggled with profound inner turmoil while composing his intensely introspective and emotionally charged Sixth Symphony. Using music as an outlet for his anguish, longing, and profound despair, he poured his soul into a work that is as far-reaching as it is personal. His death just nine days after its premiere only added weight to this defining work of the Romantic period. One of the many legends that surround the work is that Tchaikovsky's brother Modest came up with the name ""Pathétique"" which in his native Russian suggests "impassioned suffering." Whether or not the composer acquiesced to this christening before his sudden death, it is uncannily suitable for the devastating psychological drama the symphony lays bare. In the hands of Jaime Martín, time-worn scores like Tchaikovsky's quickly turn into fresh, spellbinding moments, an ability which has quickly cemented him as a favorite guest collaborator of your Colorado Symphony.

On the first half, Martín teams up with our very own Principal Cellist Seoyoen Min to perform Shostakovich's First Cello Concerto, whose qualities of mocking wit alternating with abject gloom kept Shostakovich in hot water with the cultural commissars for much of his creative life – rounding out a weekend of masterful music-making at Boettcher Concert Hall.

Jaime Martín, conductor
Seoyoen Min, cello

BACEWICZ Overture; SHOSTAKOVICH Cello Concerto No. 1 in E-flat major, Op. 107*
—INTERMISSION—TCHAIKOVSKY Symphony No. 6 in B minor, Op. 74, "Pathétique"
*feat. Seoyoen Min

February 20-22

Shostakovich Piano Concerto No. 1 with Olga Kern

Denver favorite Olga Kern returns, lending dazzling technique and searing musicianship to Shostakovich's witty Piano Concerto No. 1. The piece – a rule-breaking, neo-baroque romp filled with sardonic humor, parody, and fleeting musical quotes – is actually a double concerto supported by string orchestra in which the piano converses with solo trumpet, played by our inimitable Principal Trumpet Justin Bartels.

Sergei Rachmaninoff, so highly regarded for his own prodigious piano concertos, finally placed himself among the greats of the symphonic form with the completion of his Second Symphony. A romantic tour de force, this luxurious work brims with emotion as heart-wrenching melodies unfold across its four breathtaking movements. With the always-vibrant Christopher Dragon on the podium, this is a program that will leave you simply spellbound.

Christopher Dragon, conductor
Olga Kern, piano
Justin Bartels, trumpet

MUSSORGSKY The Fair at Sorochinski: Gopak
SHOSTAKOVICH Piano Concerto No. 1 in C minor, Op. 35*
—INTERMISSION—
RACHMANINOFF Symphony No. 2 in E minor, Op. 27
*feat. Olga Kern & Justin Bartels

March 6-8

Beethoven Symphony No. 3 "Eroica"

History is replete with turning points, and with the "Eroica" (Heroic), Beethoven forever changed the idea of what a symphony could be. Beethoven's passion rises to the forefront in this work, using broad strokes of sound to convey the very nature of humanity while reimagining a future for music filled with endless possibilities. With his deft mastery of late-Classical music, Markus Stenz is a perfect fit to lead a piece which advances the symphonic genre into a full exploration of what it means to be human.

But be sure to get to your seat early, or risk missing the elegant compositional voice of Louise Farrenc, Beethoven's preeminent female contemporary, who was a tenacious advocate for women's equality, often clashing with the authorities as she strove to earn pay equal to male counterparts. As a counterweight to these 1800s treasures, virtuoso James Ehnes showcases his talents in Korngold's Violin Concerto, the late work of a prodigy whose music is usually heard on the silver screen, not in the concert hall. With its extraordinary sophistication and romantic energy so revered in Korngold's film scores including "The Adventures of Robin Hood" and "The Sea Hawk", the Violin Concerto calls on its soloist to display both extreme virtuosity and angelic lyricism in a cinematic adventure that transcends his Hollywood success and completes this picture-perfect program.

Markus Stenz, conductor
James Ehnes, violin

FARRENC Overture No. 1 in E minor, Op. 23
KORNGOLD Violin Concerto in D major, Op. 35*
—INTERMISSION—
BEETHOVEN Symphony No. 3 in E-flat major, Op. 55, "Eroica"
*feat. James Ehnes

March 20-22

Prokofiev Romeo and Juliet with Peter Oundjian

From the opening blasts of Verdi's La forza Overture to the last breaths of the star-crossed lovers in Prokofiev's enchanting ballet score, this program promises to be a memorable journey you won't experience anywhere else. Music Director Peter Oundjian has hand-selected highlights from Romeo and Juliet in a specially curated suite for the concert hall, featuring unforgettable moments in Prokofiev's retelling like the famous "balcony scene," and the intense drama of The Death of Tybalt.

On the first half, experience the world premiere of American composer Christopher Theofanidis' latest composition – a brand-new double concerto for Violin and Percussion that was commissioned by the Colorado Symphony. This concerto will feature Concertmaster Yumi Hwang-Williams and guest Svet Stoyanov, one of the most important artists and pedagogues in the percussion world today. It all comes together in a thrilling collaboration with the orchestra that you will need to see to believe.

Peter Oundjian, conductor
Yumi Hwang-Williams, violin
Svet Stoyanov, percussion

VERDI La forza del destino: Overture
THEOFANIDIS Violin/Percussion Concerto Commission* —INTERMISSION—
PROKOFIEV Romeo and Juliet, Op. 64
*feat. Yumi Hwang-Williams and Svet Stoyanov

April 10-12

Marin Alsop Conducts Scheherazade

The spirit of adventure is calling as your Colorado Symphony and beloved Conductor Laureate Marin Alsop present Rimsky-Korsakov's Scheherazade, an exhilarating journey through love, intrigue, and suspense. This poignant adaptation of the classic Arabian Nights tale casts the violin as the cunning Scheherazade, who outwits her murderous Sultan husband through the telling of enchanting stories. Rimsky-Korsakov's score is filled with dynamic emotion and riveting melodies that will instantly transport you into a fairytale world.

Venezuelan pianist Gabriela Montero's "Latin" Concerto shows why she is a true dual threat as composer and performer. She calls the piece "a chiaroscuro reflection on who we are as a continent, dark and light, with all the rhythms, charm, and sensuality that people love about Latin America." But listeners will discover that not all that glitters is gold as her homeland's beauty blinds the world to the corruption, violence, and poverty that threaten to consume it. Gabriela Ortiz's Antrópolis narrates the sound of Mexico City through its legendary dance halls and nightclubs in a piece The New York Times raved, "would make the Leonard Bernstein of 'West Side Story' jealous." With Marin Alsop on the podium, this program is a dazzling celebration of women in music.

Marin Alsop, conductor
Gabriela Montero, piano

GABRIELA ORTIZ Antrópolis
GABRIELA MONTERO Piano Concerto No. 1, "Latin"" Concerto*
—INTERMISSION—
RIMSKY-KORSAKOV Scheherazade
*feat. Gabriela Montero

April 24-26

Gershwin Rhapsody in Blue with Michelle Cann

One of the most sought-after pianists of her generation, Michelle Cann joins your Colorado Symphony to deliver a double-header piano showcase of Gershwin's Rhapsody in Blue – a uniquely American standard occupying the intersection between classical music, jazz, and Broadway – and Florence Price's Piano Concerto in One Movement. Price's Late Romantic background and her deep understanding of African-American spiritual combine for stop-in-your-tracks-beautiful moments, which Cann brings to life in a work that was almost lost to time before being reconstructed from manuscripts just fifteen years ago.

If the second half of this concert concerns the deep and the blue, the first is an exploration of the sea, as Peter Oundjian leads you through two vivid depictions of the open ocean. Listen to the clarity and calm of waves at dawn and the immense power of the storm in operatic interludes from Britten's Peter Grimes: Four Sea Interludes. Then enjoy Debussy's La Mer which so alluringly blurs the senses, blending shimmering colors to replicate the play of light on water and vivid sense of motion to form a magical, ever-changing soundscape.

Peter Oundjian, conductor
Michelle Cann, piano

BRITTEN Peter Grimes: Four Sea Interludes Op. 33a
DEBUSSY La mer
—INTERMISSION—
PRICE Piano Concerto in One Movement*
GERSHWIN Rhapsody in Blue*
*feat. Michelle Cann

May 1-3

Stravinsky The Rite of Spring

When Jess Gillam isn't in the recording studio or serenading audiences with her acclaimed saxophone playing, she can be heard hosting her award-winning BBC radio program, This Classical Life. In Gillam's bold, uplifting, and open-minded approach composer Anna Clyne found the perfect soloist to champion her new saxophone concerto, Glasslands, in which she lets loose the Irish folkloric spirit of the banshee through the virtuosity of the solo instrument.

In a program celebrating the fresh and new of the symphonic world, a fitting conclusion is Stravinsky's riotous Rite of Spring, which with its rhythmic complexity, lush dissonance, and harsh sonorities retains its magnetic modernity over a century after a premiere which infamously shocked unsuspecting Parisian crowds. All this, as well as the drama of Beethoven's Coriolan Overture, will exhilarate under the sure-handed and suave baton of conductor Kevin John Edusei.

Kevin John Edusei, conductor
Jess Gillam, soprano saxophone

BEETHOVEN Coriolan Overture, Op. 62
ANNA CLYNE Glasslands*
—INTERMISSION—
STRAVINSKY The Rite of Spring
*feat. Jess Gillam

May 15-17

Pictures at an Exhibition with Christopher Dragon

Promenade with the Colorado Symphony through the gallery of one of the most celebrated and colorful works in the symphonic catalogue: Ravel's famous orchestration of Mussorgsky's Pictures at an Exhibition. From its regal opening to its majestic finale, Mussorgsky's work is a perennial favorite characterized by immersions into the worlds of its various paintings.

Before intermission, experience Brahms' intimate and autumnal Second Piano Concerto with up-and-coming soloist Albert Cano Smit. Brahms' work, a showcase of a composer at the peak of his powers, tells a story so monumental it stretched the concerto genre from the customary three movements to four. Don't miss a rising star make an impressively mature debut in a work showcasing soloist and orchestra

Christopher Dragon, conductor
Albert Cano Smit, piano

BERLIOZ Rákóczi March
BRAHMS Piano Concerto No. 2 in B-flat major, Op. 83*
—INTERMISSION—
MUSSORGSKY Pictures at an Exhibition (arr. Ravel)
*feat. Albert Cano Smit

May 29-31

Mahler Symphony No. 2 "Resurrection" with Peter Oundjian

Music Director Peter Oundjian, the Colorado Symphony Chorus, a pair of incredible vocal soloists, and your very own Colorado Symphony join forces for an unforgettable sendoff to our concert season with Mahler's colossal "Resurrection" symphony. This titanic work deals with nothing less than the meaning of life, as Mahler confronts an existential quest for understanding amid the challenges and incomprehensibilities we all experience. A gripping, emotional work of striking brilliance, Mahler's passionate, stylish, and explosive symphonic journey concludes with an expression of hope and optimism that will leave you awestruck.

Peter Oundjian, conductor
Andrea Carroll, soprano
Susan Platts, mezzo-soprano
Colorado Symphony Chorus,
Taylor Martin, director

MAHLER Symphony No. 2 in C minor, "Resurrection